

Philip Johnson, 98, ever-evolving dean of architects

By Robert Campbell
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Philip Johnson, the most famous and controversial American architect of his time, died Tuesday night at his estate in New Canaan, Conn. He was 98.

Mr. Johnson kept himself in the forefront of the architectural scene for more than 70 years. He stayed ahead of the pack by frequently changing styles, being always among the first to latch onto a new trend.

"He did more than anyone else in his time to promote the importance of architecture to the American people," said Glenn Lowry, director of the Museum of Modern Art in New York.

Over the years, Mr. Johnson's practice grew from houses to art museums to large corporate developments. He designed approximately a hundred works in all.

Among the better known are his famous Glass House in New Canaan; the sculpture garden at MoMA, recently restored to its original condition; Pennzoil Place office towers in Houston; the Museum of Pre-Columbian Art at Dumbarton Oaks in Washington; the vast Crystal Cathedral in Garden Grove, Calif.; IDS Center in Minneapolis; and 885 Third Avenue in New York, known as the Lipstick Building because of its shape.

He designed dozens of office buildings during a partnership with John Burgee, which lasted from 1967 to 1991. To give his corporate clients the unique "signature" look they wanted, Mr. Johnson began milking architectural history for a variety of styles.

An example is Boston's International Place, a cluster of towers partly sheathed in an endless pattern of Renaissance-style "Palladian" windows. It is one of three Mr. Johnson works in Boston: the others are an addition to the Boston Public Library, which the architect himself came to dislike; and an office and retail complex at 500 Boylston St. in the Back Bay.

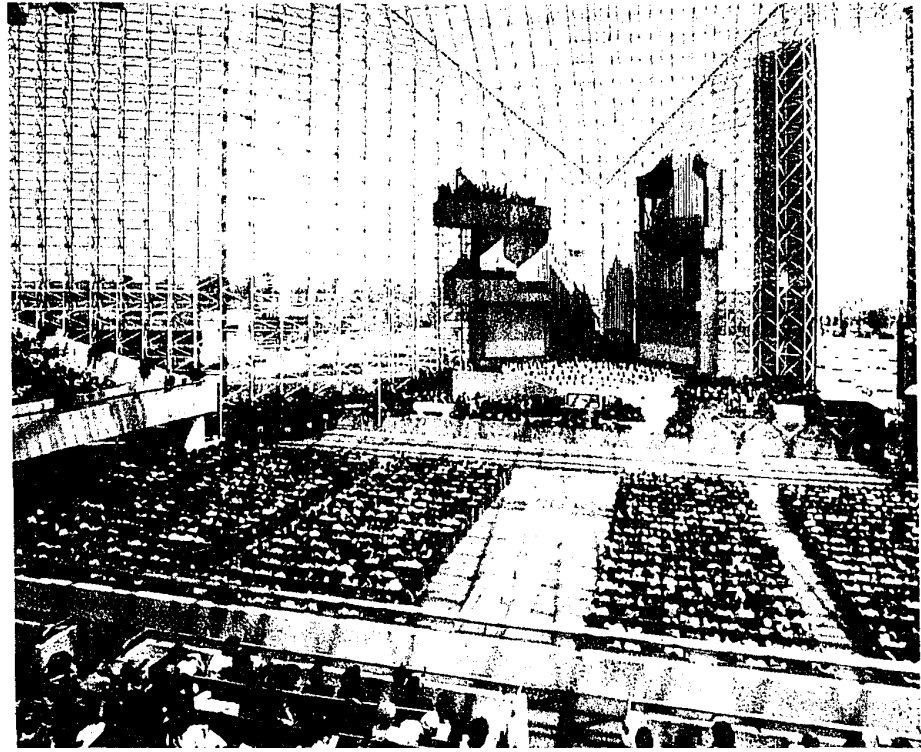
Mr. Johnson became a practicing architect only at the age of 40, but long before that, as a critic and museum curator, he was a major force. For decades, he virtually dictated the tastes of the Museum of Modern Art through its architectural exhibits. His regular lunchtime table at the Four Seasons restaurant in New York was itself a small capital of world architecture. He was also a major collector and donor of modern art.

"He was a mentor to me," said Frank Gehry, perhaps today's most celebrated American architect. "He was a champion supporter of ideas, and I guess I intrigued him."

Witty and provocative, Mr. Johnson loved to shock. He enjoyed being an object of controversy.

The peak of his public fame probably occurred in January 1979, when his design of the American Telephone and Telegraph headquarters tower in Manhattan landed him on the cover of Time magazine. The AT&T — now the Sony Building — featured a top that looked like a Chippendale clock and a base that recalled the Pazzi Chapel in Renaissance Florence. It signaled Mr. Johnson's influential rejection of the modern style and helped inaugurate the style called postmodernism, an approach in which a building, like an actor, could don the costume of any style of the past.

The mercurial Mr. Johnson never stopped changing.



AP FILE PHOTO

CRYSTAL CATHEDRAL — Mr. Johnson designed the church for Rev. Robert Schuller in Garden Grove, Calif., in 1980.

In 1988, well into his ninth decade, he co-curated an exhibit at the Museum of Modern Art on yet another style, "Deconstructivist Architecture," showing buildings by Gehry and others that looked as if they'd been freeze-framed at the moment of exploding.

Fifty-six years earlier, it was another exhibition at MoMA that brought Mr. Johnson his first notoriety. In 1932, he helped organize "The International Style." More than any other event, this show introduced Americans to the modern movement in architecture as it had developed during the 1920s in Europe, among such figures as Walter Gropius (founder of the Bauhaus school), Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, and Le Corbusier.

Still active until the final few months of his life, Mr. Johnson started a firm with a partner in 1994, when he was in his mid-80s. Among its many projects, some never built, were a town hall for the Walt Disney Co. in Florida, a chapel in Houston, and an office building in Berlin. There was also a proposal for a Manhattan site done for developer Donald Trump. Outspoken as ever, Mr. Johnson told a magazine editor why Trump had picked him: "He's interested in the name because it makes him look like a patron of the arts."

The scion of a wealthy Ohio family, Philip Courtelyou Johnson was born in Cleveland Heights on July 8, 1906. He majored in philosophy at Harvard and became a lifelong devotee of the German thinker Friedrich Nietzsche, from whom he absorbed the concept that God was dead and there was nothing left to worship except art. It was a mantra he repeated to the end of his life.

At Harvard, Mr. Johnson suffered manic-depressive cycles and two breakdowns, which he later attributed to his homosexuality. He took seven years to graduate. Yet within months — thanks to a chance friendship with Alfred Barr, the director of the new Museum of Modern Art — Mr. Johnson, who had never formally studied architecture, was curator of MoMA's architecture department.

During the 1930s Mr. Johnson abandoned architecture for right-

wing politics. He attended a Nazi rally near Berlin, where he was enthralled by Adolf Hitler and — as he told a biographer long afterwards — "all those blond boys in black leather." He became a Nazi fellow-traveler, published racist articles, and in September 1939 followed Hitler's armies into Poland as a correspondent for Social Justice, a magazine published by the American radio extremist Father Charles Coughlin.

In Poland he encountered the journalist William Shirer, who later wrote in his best-selling book "Berlin Diary": "None of us can stand the fellow and suspect he is spying on us for the Nazis." To an interviewer decades later, he explained his politics of the 1930s, which he came to regret, as having been motivated by architecture: "I thought the fascist dictators were going to build in a grander way than the democracies, by analogy to the papacy and the monarchies."

When the United States entered World War II, Mr. Johnson enrolled as a student at the Harvard architecture school. Using his inherited wealth, he built and occupied one of his student design projects, a house that still stands in Cambridge. He graduated at the top of his class in 1943. He then was drafted into the Army, where, closely monitored by the FBI, he spent most of his service cleaning kitchens and latrines.

After the war, Mr. Johnson regained his position at the Museum of Modern Art. He also began a career as a practicing architect. He gained a reputation by designing the Glass House in New Canaan in 1949, an elegant steel-and-glass box on a well-kept lawn. It is still his best known work. In the 1950s, he collaborated with the modernist he most admired, Mies van der Rohe, on the design of the Seagram Building on Park Avenue in New York.

Mr. Johnson created his own memorial in 1987 when he bequeathed his estate in Connecticut to the National Trust for Historic Preservation, to be opened to the public after his death and maintained through an endowment created by the sale of some paint-

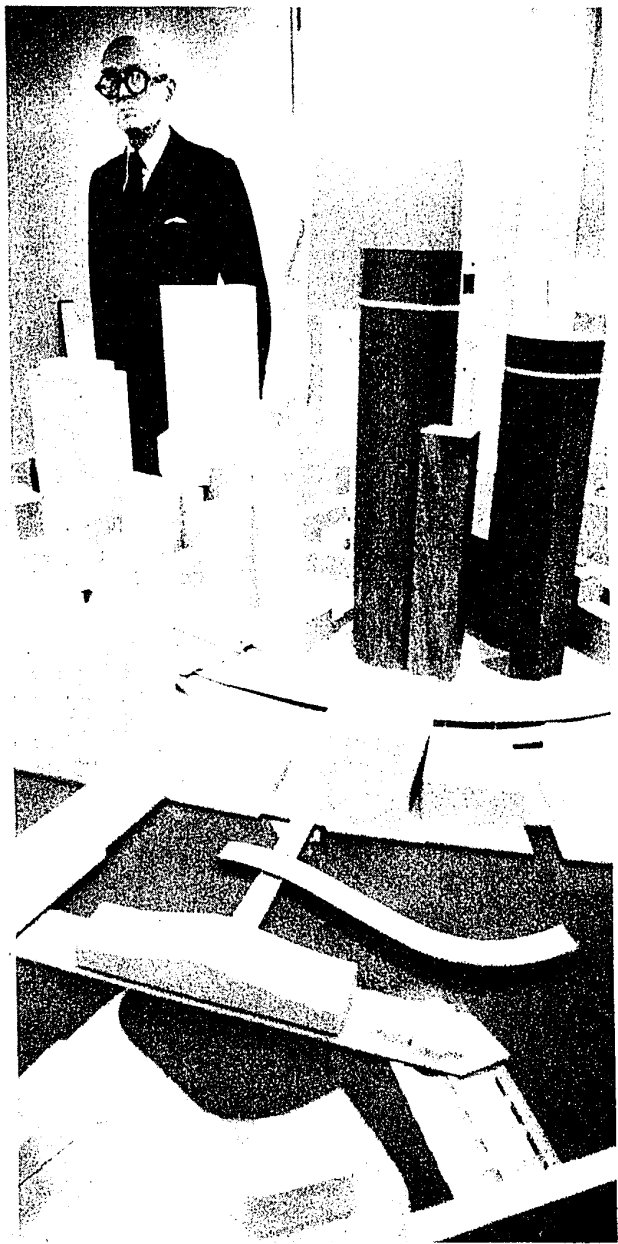
ings. The property, which the architect designed and built as a retreat over a period of five decades, includes the Glass House and other small buildings and sculptures, each in a different style.

Mr. Johnson received many honors. When the international Pritzker Prize was established in 1979 — intended as the architectural equivalent of a Nobel — Mr. Johnson was named its first winner. He was the author or subject of numerous books, most notably "Philip Johnson: Life and Work," a biography by Franz Schulze (1994). A familiar figure in celebrity circles, Mr. Johnson dressed elegantly in dark custom-tailored suits and in later years wore owl-like black-rimmed glasses, a personal signature that Mr. Johnson imitated from the French architect Le Corbusier.

Mr. Johnson often noted his lack of originality. "I'm not a form-giver," he said. Throughout his life he was generous in promoting the work of others and helped make the careers of many younger rivals. He was a person of enormous intelligence and personal charm, who could enchant you even while manipulating you. Mr. Johnson would execute a series of polished evasions and outrageous flatteries, then suddenly tip his hand with a candid word or gesture — sharing the joke, letting you in on the trick he was performing at your expense, and enticing you to collude in your own exploitation. It was a kind of genius.

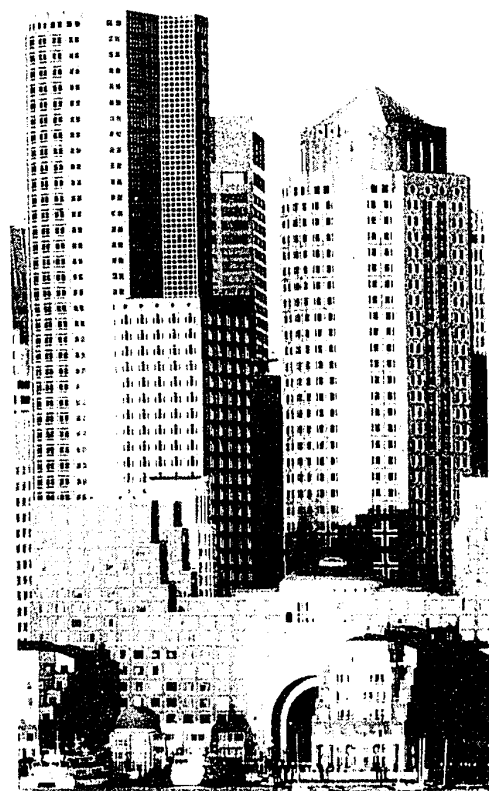
Observers often noted that there seemed to be two Philip Johnsons. One was the brilliant, sometimes arrogant Nietzschean who never compromised his love of art. The other was a glad-handing cultural politician, perhaps the most successful of his era. It was the second who, in 1980, designed the Crystal Cathedral in California for the television evangelist Robert Schuller. A lifelong atheist, Mr. Johnson informed Schuller's congregation, in a voice apparently breaking with emotion, that he couldn't have done it without help from above.

Mr. Johnson leaves his longtime companion, David Whitney; and a sister, Jeannette Dempsey.



1983 GLOBE STAFF FILE PHOTO/WENDY MAEDA

INTERNATIONAL PLACE — Philip Johnson, with a model of Boston's waterfront in the boardroom of the Boston Redevelopment Authority. Mr. Johnson's contribution to the skyline was International Place, the tall buildings behind Rowe's Wharf (bottom).



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